

Spiritual Gifts

Note: Second sentence in the summary is from Living Water" by Chuck Smith and will have a chapter reference.

Service (Ministry/Helps)

A divine enablement to notice and meet practical needs in the church body, often behind the scenes; marked by faithfulness, cheerfulness, and a servant's heart. A quiet, faithful willingness to serve wherever needed, reflecting the Paraclete's heart of humble assistance (Ch 17).

Bible: Dorcas ("Tabitha") clothed the widows of Joppa, and the church mourned deeply when she died (Acts 9:36-39).

Today: Coordinating food deliveries for a homebound member of the congregation or Running the church nursery week after week so parents can attend worship without distraction.

Teaching

The ability to understand, clarify, and communicate Scripture so others can learn and apply biblical truth accurately. Uttering the "milk" and "meat" of Scripture with clarity so believers grow strong in foundational truths (Ch 18).

Bible: Paul "explained and solemnly testified" the kingdom of God to the Ephesians over three years (Acts 20:20-21). Jesus explained the mysteries of the kingdom in parables so that those with "ears to hear" would understand (Matt 13:10-13).

Today: Developing a small-group curriculum that unpacks a New Testament book. Leading an inductive small group through the parables of Christ, helping newcomers grasp kingdom principles.

Encouragement (Exhortation)

A gift of coming alongside others to uplift, comfort, urge action, and strengthen faith through timely words and presence. A Spirit-prompted ability to stir others toward obedience, hope, and steadfastness (Ch 19).

Bible: Barnabas "encouraged" the new believers in Antioch to remain true to the Lord with all their hearts (Acts 11:23).

Today: Sending regular notes or calls to new believers to bolster their walk with Christ. Hosting a monthly "faith-builders" lunch for recent converts to spur them on in their walk.

Giving

A supernatural generosity in managing and sharing resources—time, talents, possessions—cheerfully and sacrificially to meet the church's needs. A Spirit-driven generosity that delights in sharing resources to further the kingdom without hesitation (Ch 20).

Bible: The Macedonian churches gave “beyond their ability,” begging for the privilege of supporting the Jerusalem saints (2 Cor 8:3–5).

Today: Funding a mission trip for a financially strapped missionary family. Sacrificially underwriting a short-term mission team's housing so that cost won't hinder the gospel.

Leadership (Government/Administration)

The capacity to govern, organize, and oversee people and projects with diligence, vision, and wisdom to advance the church's mission. The gift of orchestrating people and plans, carrying responsibility with humility and vision (Ch 21).

Bible: Nehemiah organized the rebuilding of Jerusalem's walls, marshaling builders, supplies, and protection plans (Neh 2:17–18).

Today: Chairing a church board that launches a new community outreach program. Directing a multi-team church plant launch—recruiting leaders, setting budgets, and charting the timeline.

Mercy

A compassionate gift enabling one to feel and act upon others' suffering, offering practical care and emotional support without growing weary. A tender compassion that moves one to action whenever suffering is spotted, reflecting Christ's heart (Ch 22).

Bible: Jesus' compassion moved Him to heal the sick and feed the hungry multitudes (Matt. 14:14). Moved with compassion, Jesus fed the 5,000 after they'd been following Him all day hungry (Matt 15:32).

Today: Visiting and caring for chronically ill or grieving members with empathy and consistency. Organizing a church-wide food pantry and personally delivering groceries to struggling families.

Pastor (Pastor/Teacher ~ Shepherd)

A dual gifting to shepherd God's flock—nurturing spiritual growth, protecting from false teaching, and equipping them through teaching. A combined shepherd-teacher role, caring for souls, protecting truth, and feeding the flock (implied in Ch 6).

Bible: Peter exhorted the elders, “Shepherd the flock of God...not for dishonest gain, but eagerly,” setting himself as an example (1 Pet 5:2–3).

Today: Leading a church family through life's seasons with regular teaching and personal care. Scheduling regular “office hours” to meet one-on-one with members for counsel, prayer, and accountability.

Helps

Similar to Service but often more task-oriented: enabling leaders and ministry teams to function effectively by handling practical details. The “quiet ministry” of stepping in wherever tasks need doing so leaders can focus on their calling (Ch 17).

Bible: The seven deacons were appointed to oversee the daily distribution so the apostles could devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the Word (Acts 6:3–4).

Today: Setting up and tearing down equipment for weekly worship services.

Speaking

A Spirit-breathed capacity to speak God's truth into situations—encouraging, warning, or revealing His will—always under Scripture's authority. The gift of “speaking forth the Word of God,” bringing fresh revelation or timely conviction (Ch 13).

Bible: Agabus predicted a great famine, and the disciples acted on his word by sending relief to Judea (Acts 11:27–28).

Today: Sharing a timely word of warning about a moral compromise facing the congregation.

Faith

A heightened trust in God's character and promises that moves Him to act miraculously beyond ordinary believers' conviction. "How to plant a mulberry tree in the ocean"—believing God for the impossible and seeing Him move miraculously (Ch 10).

Bible: Abraham's faith was credited as righteousness when he believed God would give him descendants (Rom. 4:20-22). The centurion's faith amazed Jesus when he declared, "Just speak the word, and my servant will be healed" (Matt 8:8–10).

Today: Praying confidently for God to provide funding or meet a need, or do a work.

Evangelist

A compelling gift to proclaim the gospel with clarity and power, leading non-believers to repentance and faith in Christ. A passion to see unbelievers saved, moving like Philip in Samaria to spread the good news (Ch 5–6).

Bible: Philip's preaching brought multitudes in Samaria to faith and baptism (Acts 8:5–6).

Today: Organizing and speaking at outreach events that introduce Christ to the unreached. Personally share the gospel with strangers.

Discernment (Discerning Spirits)

The ability to distinguish between true and false spiritual influences—identifying deceit, deception, or genuine divine movement. "Unmasking the evil one"—the Spirit's enablement to detect counterfeit spirits and safeguard truth (Ch 14).

Bible: Filled with the Holy Spirit, Paul rebuked Elymas the sorcerer and pronounced temporary blindness on him (Acts 13:9–11).

Today: Recognizing and warning the church about a charismatic teacher whose doctrine subtly erodes biblical truth or subtly departs from biblical orthodoxy.

(Word of) Knowledge

A supernatural insight into specific facts or details—often about a person’s situation—revealed by the Holy Spirit for encouragement or guidance. “How did He know that?”—instantaneous insight into hidden truths or circumstances by the Spirit (Ch 9).

Bible: Ananias, by a word of knowledge, told Saul he would regain his sight—and it happened just as he said (Acts 9:10–12).

Today: Over coffee with a longtime friend, you suddenly share a Spirit-given warning about her fiancé’s unscriptural divorce—information you couldn’t have known naturally—which prompts her to pause and seek God’s guidance before proceeding.

(“Different Kinds of”) Tongues

Speaking in unlearned, Spirit-given languages—either human or heavenly—to edify the speaker or, with interpretation, the congregation. “An affront to the intellect; a blessing to the soul”—Spirit-given heavenly or earthly languages that build the speaker (Ch 15).

Bible: On Pentecost the disciples spoke in various tongues as the Spirit enabled (Acts 2:4, 8-11).

Today: Uttering praise in an unknown tongue during personal prayer time for spiritual refreshment. Private prayer in an ecstatic tongue. Lynn laid hands on Jan and prayed in flawless, aristocratic French—though she’d never studied it—interceding for Jan’s ministry, and Jan trembled as she realized the Holy Spirit was praying through Lynn on her behalf.

Interpretation of Tongues

The gift to translate or explain Spirit-given tongues into the local language, so the whole church may understand and be edified. “What did He say?”—bringing the mystery of tongues into understandable edification (Ch 16).

Bible: In Corinth, one with the gift of interpretation ensured that every tongue-utterance built up the church (1 Cor 14:27–28).

Today: Translating a Spirit-given tongue-utterance into clear English during a multiethnic service.

(Gifts of) Healings

A capacity to pray and see God restore physical or emotional health, often instantaneously, as a sign of His kingdom. “Hope for the Sick”—the manifold grace to pray for and witness God’s restoration of health (Ch 11).

Bible: Peter healed Aeneas, and all who dwelt at Lydda turned to the Lord (Acts 9:33-35).

Today: Praying over stroke survivors who then experience unexpected recoveries. Leading a prayer team that sees several cancer patients experience unexplainable remissions.

(Working of) Miracles

Enabling God’s power to transcend natural laws—performing “signs and wonders” that authenticate the gospel message. “The hardest gift to possess”—manifesting God’s power to suspend natural laws, authenticating the gospel (Ch 12).

Bible: Paul’s handkerchiefs and aprons delivered the sick and demon-possessed at Ephesus (Acts 19:11-12).

Today: Witnessing a dramatic deliverance from demonic bondage in a church healing service.

(Word of) Wisdom

A divinely imparted application of knowledge and insight for complex situations—often providing godly counsel or strategy. “The Word of Wisdom”—Spirit-imparted counsel that brings divine strategy into complex situations (Ch 8).

Bible: Joseph interpreted Pharaoh’s dreams and advised how Egypt should store grain (Gen. 41:39-41). Solomon’s wise judgment between two harlots over a living baby revealed true motherhood (1 Kings 3:16–28).

Today: Advising a pastoral search committee on the Spirit-led selection of a new pastor. Guiding a school-board-style committee to prioritize ministries that yield the most kingdom impact.

Apostle

Sent ones who establish and oversee churches, lay doctrinal foundations, and pioneer gospel advance in unreached regions. “Unity in Diversity”—sent ones who pioneer churches, lay foundations, and oversee new works (Ch 7 intro).

Bible: Paul planted multiple congregations across Asia Minor and wrote epistles to strengthen them (Rom 15:20-24).

Today: Church planters who launch and shepherd new congregations in non-Christian areas.

Prophet

One who receives and communicates direct revelation from God—forth-telling His Word, calling for repentance, or fore-telling future events. “Speaking Forth the Word of God”—a direct channel for God’s voice, calling for repentance or revealing future events (Ch 13).

Bible: Agabus predicted both famine and Paul’s imprisonment, guiding the church’s response (Acts 11:27-28; 21:10-11).

Today: Delivering a message of warning and hope that aligns with Scripture and bears fruit. Delivering a timely word of conviction that ushers in corporate repentance and renewal.